WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

NORTH MACEDONIA

Europe

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Skopje	Capital and largest economy; seat of government, the National Bank and most international firms, and home to the largest technological industrial development zones	Automotive components, ICT, business services, logistics
Tetovo–Gostivar (Corridor 8)	First section of the Corridor 8 motorway being built by ENKA–Bechtel towards the Albanian border	Construction, manufacturing, trade
Prilep–Bitola (Corridor 10d)	Southern section of the new motorway programme, improving links towards Greece	Food processing, tobacco, energy, logistics
Ohrid and Struga	Lakeside tourism centre linked to Albania by the Struga–Kjafasan motorway section	Tourism, hospitality, real estate
Corridor 10 (Kumanovo–Veles–Gevgelija)	Main north–south road and rail route linking Serbia with Greece and the port of Thessaloniki	Logistics, manufacturing, agri-food exports
Štip and the east	Manufacturing region with a technological industrial development zone	Textiles, automotive components, agriculture

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Invest North Macedonia, the government's investment and export promotion agency, provides facilitation and guidance on incentives
- Technological industrial development zones (TIDZs) offering a 10-year profit-tax exemption, customs and VAT relief, and up to €500,000 towards construction costs
- A flat 10% corporate income tax, with a 1% turnover regime for small companies
- A denar managed against the euro, giving euro-based investors a stable currency, supported by reserves of €5.2 billion in March 2026
- EU candidate status since 2005 and a Stabilisation and Association Agreement giving preferential access to the EU market
- Public infrastructure programmes, including the Corridor 8 and 10d motorways due for completion by December 2029

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

North Macedonia in November 2026 offers investors a low-tax, euro-linked manufacturing base on the main corridors between Central Europe and Greece, with growth gathering pace. GDP grew 3.5% in 2025, according to the IMF, and accelerated to 4.3% year-on-year in the second quarter of 2026, the strongest rate since late 2024, as gross investment rose 16.5%, construction 21.9% and exports 10.4%. Inflation was 2.7% in September 2026 and the National Bank held its policy rate at 4.25% in November. Foreign exchange reserves reached €5.2 billion at the end of March 2026, and the IMF projects FDI to rise from 1.5% of GDP in 2025 to 3.8% in 2026. The ENKA–Bechtel motorway programme of about 111 km, the country's largest infrastructure project, is advancing on three sections with more than 1,550 people at work.

North Macedonia's main structural challenge is restoring momentum on EU accession and strengthening public finances. The country applied for membership in 2004 and has been a candidate since 2005, but progress depends on constitutional amendments to recognise Bulgarians as a minority, under a 2022 compromise adopted by the EU; these require a two-thirds majority that the government has not secured. The general government deficit was 4.0% of GDP in 2025, meeting its target, and the authorities aim for 3.5% in 2026; public and publicly guaranteed debt was 59.9% of GDP. The base remains solid: a flat 10% tax system, a stable currency, ample reserves and IMF-supported fiscal plans. Continued alignment with EU standards and DFI financing offer opportunities in manufacturing, energy and transport.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Stalled EU accession	Opening of negotiating clusters depends on constitutional amendments recognising Bulgarians, which lack the needed two-thirds majority	The SAA and EU alignment continue regardless; track political talks with Bulgaria and the EU for a breakthrough
Fiscal deficit and debt	The deficit was 4.0% of GDP in 2025, and the IMF sees 4.2% in 2026 without new measures, with debt of 59.9% including guarantees	Reserves are ample and the 3.5% target is set; watch for tax and spending changes in future budgets
Infrastructure cost overruns	The IMF flags cost overruns on large projects as a fiscal risk	Contractors and suppliers should secure clear payment terms; completed motorways will cut transport times
Energy prices	Higher global energy prices pushed inflation up in 2026 and raise input costs	Consider on-site renewables and long-term supply contracts; renewable investment is a growth opportunity
Labour availability	Emigration and skills mismatches make skilled labour scarce in some sectors	Locate in TIDZs with training support and partner with local technical schools and universities
Governance and judicial efficiency	Rule of law and judicial efficiency remain areas of EU attention	Use experienced local counsel and arbitration clauses; EU alignment continues to strengthen institutions

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

North Macedonia's risk profile is that of a stable, NATO-member EU candidate with a flat-tax system, a currency managed against the euro and comfortable foreign exchange reserves. It is not on the FATF grey list and is not subject to sanctions. The main issues are the stalled EU accession process, which hinges on a constitutional amendment opposed by much of the public, and a fiscal deficit of about 4% of GDP, which the government is addressing with IMF-supported targets. Inflation has been moderate at 2.7% and growth has strengthened in 2026. Investors should plan for the possibility of slower EU integration, monitor budget measures and infrastructure costs, and use the strong incentives in the TIDZs, which offer one of the most attractive packages in the region.

MARKET ACCESS

North Macedonia is a member of the WTO and of the Central European Free Trade Agreement (CEFTA), and its Stabilisation and Association Agreement with the EU gives most of its goods duty-free access to the EU, its main export market. The denar's stability against the euro lowers currency risk for trade with the euro area. The country sits on Pan-European Corridor 10, linking Serbia and Central Europe with Greece and the port of Thessaloniki, and

on Corridor 8, linking the Black Sea with the Adriatic; the new Corridor 8 and 10d motorways will improve links to Albania and Greece by December 2029. Manufacturers in the TIDZs supply European automotive and industrial supply chains.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Government of North Macedonia (Prime Minister Hristijan Mickoski)	Sets economic and fiscal policy and leads the EU accession talks, including the constitutional-amendment question	Primary reference point for strategic direction and major projects
Invest North Macedonia	Official investment and export promotion agency supporting foreign investors and incentive applications	Standard first point of contact for market entry
National Bank of the Republic of North Macedonia	Maintains denar stability against the euro and set the policy rate at 4.25%	Relevant for banking, payments and financial-sector matters
Directorate for Technological Industrial Development Zones	Manages the TIDZs and the incentive packages for investors within them	Key counterpart for manufacturing site selection
Ministry of Finance	Leads the budget, tax policy, debt management and the IMF-supported fiscal path	Key counterpart on tax, fiscal and public-finance matters
Ministry of Transport and Public Enterprise for State Roads	Clients for the Corridor 8 and 10d motorway programme with ENKA–Bechtel	Counterpart for contractors, suppliers and transport investors

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Economic Chamber of North Macedonia, the American Chamber of Commerce in North Macedonia, the Foreign Investors Council and the German-Macedonian Chamber of Commerce are the main business associations, with regular dialogue with government. Invest North Macedonia promotes the country at international forums and supports investors in the TIDZs. The European Bank for Reconstruction and Development, the European Investment Bank, the World Bank and the EU's Western Balkans Investment Framework are active in energy, transport and private-sector finance, and a Hungarian loan facility has been on-lent to companies through commercial banks. Embassies of EU member states, the United Kingdom, Turkey and the United States maintain commercial sections that are a useful source of introductions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

North Macedonia suits investors seeking a low-cost, low-tax base close to the EU: automotive-component and electrical manufacturers using TIDZ incentives to serve European supply chains; ICT and business-services companies in Skopje; logistics firms on Corridor 10 towards Thessaloniki; construction and engineering companies working on the motorway programme; and renewable-energy and agri-food investors. Investors should plan for a gradual rather than rapid EU accession path.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Invest North Macedonia and assess TIDZ incentives
Open dialogue with the agency and the TIDZ Directorate on tax exemptions, construction support and available plots.

STEP 2: Shortlist sites along the main corridors
Compare TIDZ and private sites in Skopje, Štip and along Corridors 8, 10 and 10d for access to EU markets and Thessaloniki.

STEP 3: Map EU and DFI financing
Identify EU, EBRD, EIB and World Bank programmes that can co-finance energy, transport or private-sector projects.

STEP 4: Track EU accession and fiscal policy
Monitor talks on the constitutional amendments and budget measures that may affect taxes and public investment.

STEP 5: Plan for labour and energy costs
Build skills programmes and energy-price scenarios into financial models, and consider on-site renewable supply.